

FRIENDLY FIRE

Ministers indulge in a blame game, adding to the PM's troubles

ON AVIATION CRISIS Patel wanted Chidambaram and Deora to reduce ATF prices. They accused him of lobbying for rich private players.



Murli Deora



P. Chidambaram



Praful Patel

ON JAMIA NAGAR Patel is under attack from some UPA allies seeking a judicial probe into the Batla House encounter but he has refused.



Kapil Sibal



Lalu Prasad



R.V. Paswan



Shivraj Patil

ON HOMOSEXUALITY Ramadoss wants to decriminalise homosexuality but Patil says this will only legalise sexual abuse and 'unnatural acts'.



Shivraj Patil

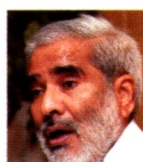


A. Ramadoss

ON NREGA Aiyar wants to decentralise the NREGA funds at the panchayat level whereas Yadav thinks the current system is just fine.



M.S. Aiyar



R.P. Yadav

ON RAJ THACKERAY Pawar is playing to his Maratha votebank and is not in favour of banning Thackeray's party while Lalu wants justice for Biharis.



S. Pawar



Lalu Prasad

ON SCHOOL MEALS Some of her male colleagues did not approve of Chowdhury's plans to centralise the ready-to-eat meals for school kids.



R. Chowdhury



M.S. Aiyar



Jaipal Reddy

crackdown on the LTTE has only added to his woes. If the 16 DMK MPs quit, the Government could face a stability crisis at a time when the SP is unhappy over seat-sharing talks with the Congress.

The ego-flexing makes cabinet meetings all the more stormy. It is now a regular sight to see Yadav and Sharad Pawar grilling Patil for being 'too vague'. At other times it is Renuka Chowdhury, the minister for women and child development, taking on some of her male colleagues on her plans to centralise the ready-to-eat meals scheme for school kids, arguing that states lack infrastructure. The Minister for Panchayati Raj, Mani Shankar Aiyar, offered that the scheme could be outsourced to the panchayats, adding with a smile, "Renukaji, we know the issue is very close to your

**INSTEAD OF
BATTING FOR THE
GOVERNMENT,
MINISTERS ARE
BUSY BUILDING
THEIR OWN IMAGE.**

heart." But it was the Supreme Court which found the way to Chowdhury's heart by okaying her plans.

The way to Patel's heart is another matter altogether. He has used the retrenchment drama at Jet Airways to increase the pressure on the Government to reduce aviation turbine fuel prices. Finance Minister P. Chidambaram saw this as a blatant attempt to coerce concessions for private carriers. But it was Deora who took on Patel directly by going public with the dues owed to the oil companies by the airlines. "The issue is not what Patel has said, though I am hurt," said Deora. But he agreed to give the airlines a 30-day credit extension.

All this in addition to the Opposition attack in Parliament. Small wonder then that the prime minister took off for a week-long trip overseas in the middle of a session. Some would say he needs the break.